

I reached the point of no return when I discovered there was a whole world of refunding and couponing beyond the Sunday inserts. Like the addict searching for their next fix, I centered my life on the next big deal. I looked for pads of forms everywhere I went, from those posted on the store shelf to on-package coupons and rebates. I loved the free things, the boxes delivered to my front door, the full mailbox and bathroom shelves bowing with the weight of the bottles of shampoo, tubes of toothpaste, cleaners, and health and beauty items that only cost me pennies. As my family grew and I made the decision to stay home with my children, I liked being able to stretch our budget in such a creative way, and got a real sense of satisfaction from shopping the sales with my coupons.

It didn't take long to realize just how different I was than the average shopper, however. As I got more deeply involved in couponing and refunding, my extreme enthusiasm for the hobby was dampened only by the reaction I got from others when I attempted to share the sagas of my good deals. Initially, I was deluded into thinking that the only thing that kept them from doing what I did was their lack of knowledge. So I frequently, and at great lengths, detailed my shopping sprees.

"Guess what I saved with Venture's double coupons today?" I would gush on the phone to a friend, only to be greeted with a dead silence on the other end. Then she might lamely ask what I could possibly do with all the merchandise I'd obtained. What would we do with it? We had six children then. We'd use it eventually, share it, barter with it, or even sell it. After all, free is free.